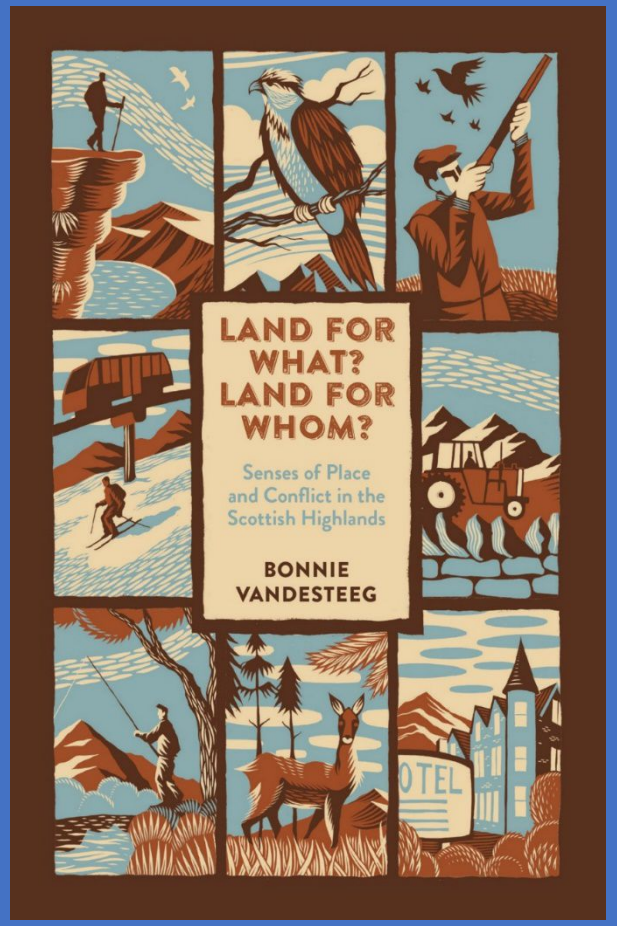
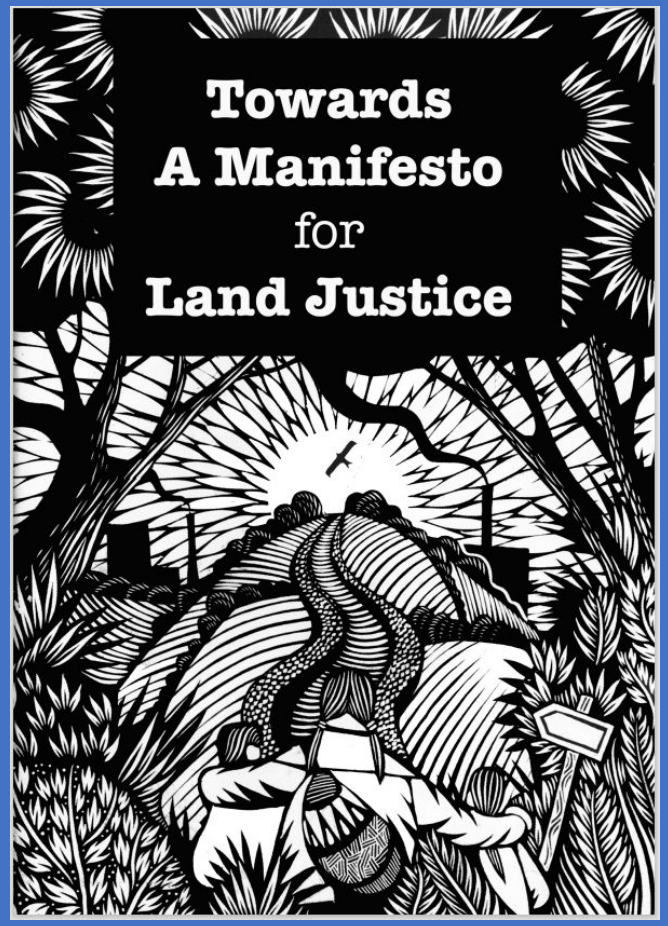
# Land Justice From Cairngorms to London



# Background to Research

- Interest in mountains and nature cross-culturally
- Anthropology and ethnographic research
- Cairngorms selected as the site of research- key conflicts going on over funicular and national park
- 1999-2000- crucial time in the setting up of the NP with the aftermath of the funicular debate still going on



# Methodology

- Immersion in everyday life over a period of time
- Listening and trying to understand
- Engaged directly in a range of activities- meeting people while doing: walking, skiing, climbing, grouse beating, birding, mountain biking, working, shopping



# Basis of research: Senses of Place

- Sense of place involves all aspects of experience, physical, emotions, intellect, socio-cultural
- Identified 3 main senses of place- recreation, conservation, livelihood
- In the same place, but see it differently, so can lead to conflict

# Conflicts: In the same space, but not the same place





# Deer versus Trees: Glen Feshie Example





# Conflict in the Cairngorms

## Livelihood



## Conservation



# Many voices are not heard





# Way forward? Power and Inequality

- Change power structures: political and economic, eg land reform and social justice
- Address economic inequality
- Increased participation in decision-making of all who live in the area, as well as those who may live elsewhere but have a commitment to both the nature and people.

**Would land reform make it easier to find common ground?**
**Does it matter who owns the land?**

SEAFIELD & STRATHSPEY ESTATES



# Community Land Scotland






# Community Ownership

## Langholm Initiative



Great outdoor dream as community tries to

A Dumfriesshire community has put the environment at the heart of its regeneration fightback and is pinning its hopes on one of Scotland's largest landowners, Buccleuch.

A once-thriving textile centre, Langholm has been dogged in recent years by industry decline and hefty job losses.

Now the Muckle Toon community wants to harness the panoramic and beautiful landscape around it to kick-start a new era. And it is banking on a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity.

Community group Langholm Initiative are in "advanced" talks with Buccleuch in a rare chance to buy almost 10,500 acres of Langholm Moor.

If successful in raising the cash, community land ownership could create the Tarras Valley Nature Reserve.

They believe it will deliver community regeneration, climate change action, ecological restoration, wildlife conservation and develop outdoor tourism, bringing new jobs and visitors to the area.

But it comes with a £6 million price tag.

Today we take a closer look at the Langholm Moor community buy-out plans and vision for the future.

Action-packed days
Young people get a taste of outdoor activities they could enjoy as part of the Langholm Moor buy-out plans

## North Kelvin Meadows

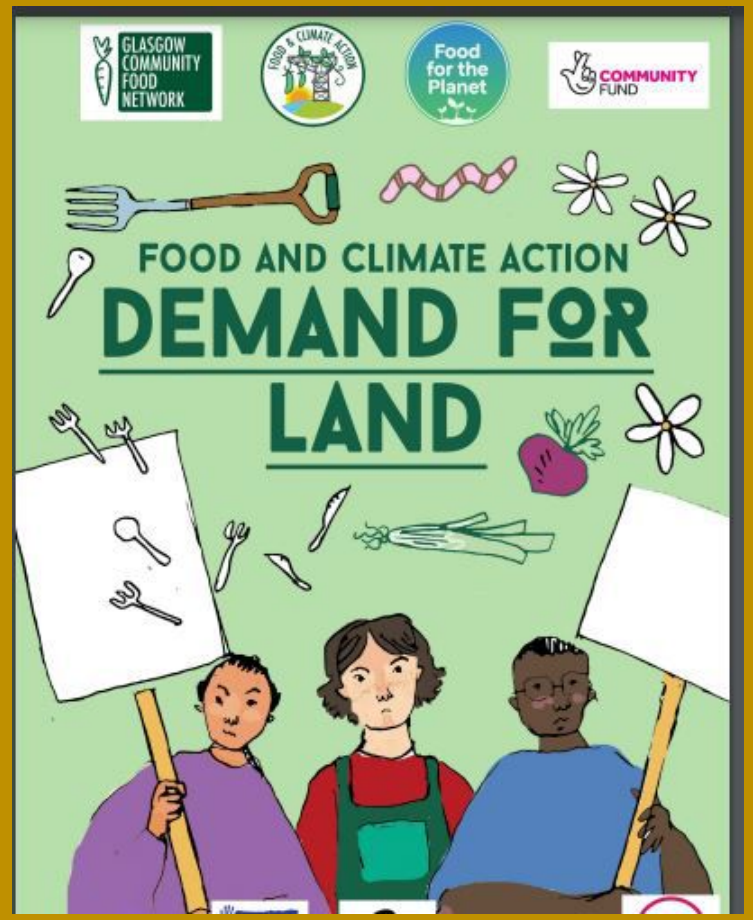


# Why Community Ownership/Stewardship

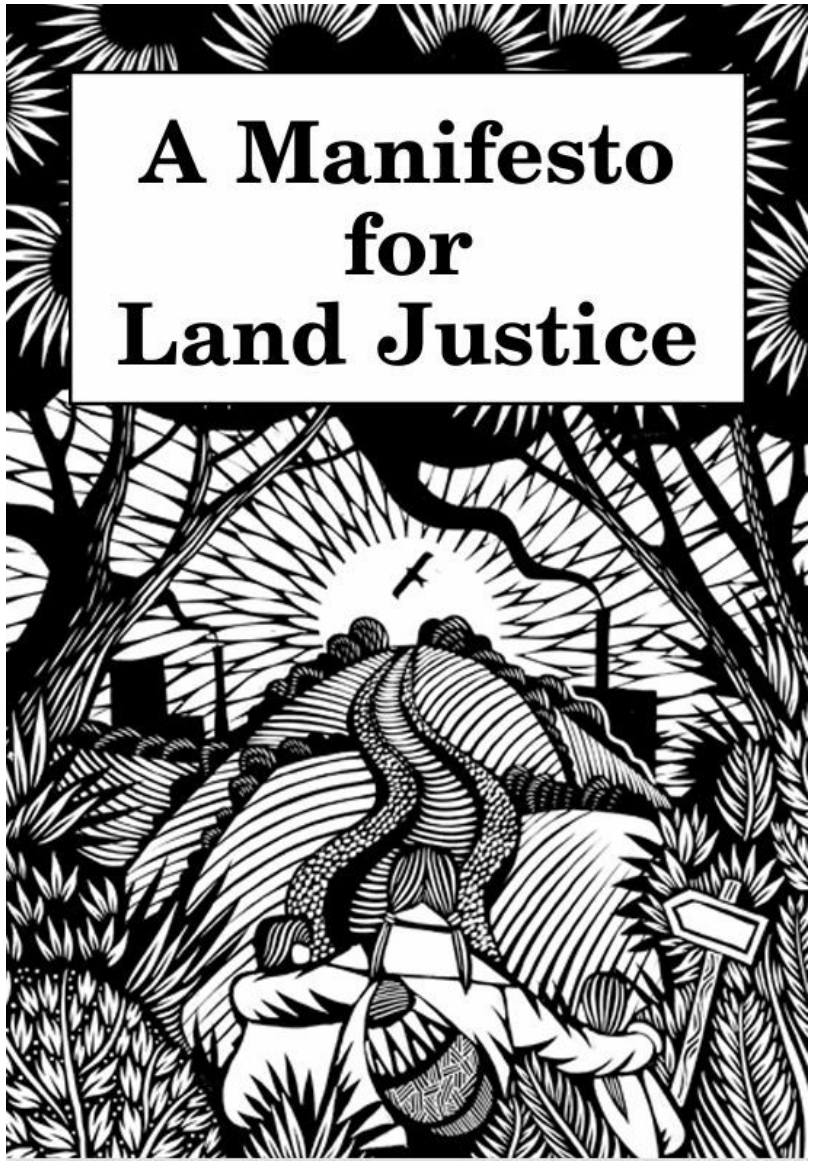
- Feeling of belonging
- More likely to care and take responsibility for the land, see the bigger picture
- Help to reduce inequalities



- Focus on public good, not private profit
- Context to bring livelihood interests and environmental aims together
- Still conflicts but all in the same space where compromises have to be made



# Peoples Land Policy: Land Reform from the Ground Up



# Land Justice London



# **London** Charter for Land Justice

**Housing**

**Climate Change**

**Food**

**Community**

**Parks and Green Spaces**

**Heritage**

**Biodiversity**

**Street Markets**

**Transport**

**Clean Air and Water**

**Right to Roam**



London belongs to **us**, those who have made our homes here and care about its future, ***not*** corporations, property developers, and others who put profit before the needs of people and the environment.

This Charter sets out our vision, principles and ideas for change that will help build a movement for land justice.

Join us!

# Demands

- Stop the sale of public land and transfer land used in a way that is harmful for the environment or community to a governance model based on stewardship
- Increase public, community and co-operative forms of ownership and address the concentration of large scale land ownership, reducing the amount of land in the hands of property developers and corporations
- Introduce a Community Right to Buy, supported by a Land Fund, such that the community can take direct control of the stewardship of the land

- **Establish Land Commissions, Land Assemblies, and other forms of collective expression, with the full involvement of the grassroots level, to achieve land justice and land reform in each London Borough**
- **Open the books to all citizens and make information about land ownership and use, as well as future property developments, free, transparent, and accessible**
- **Develop an extensive and well-resourced education programme, in schools, colleges, universities, and community education, so that all citizens have the skills and knowledge to become land stewards and participate fully in caring for the land in their locality**

.

- B VandeSteeg (2021) Land for Whom? Land for What? Senses of Place and Conflict in the Scottish Highlands www.landforwhatlandforwhom.org
- B. VandeSteeg (2024) Who Owns the Land Matters in *The Land Magazine Issue 34*
- B. VandeSteeg, Richard Lee, David King, Leslie Baron (2023) Towards Land Justice in *The Land Magazine Issue 33*
- People's Land Policy: www.peopleslandpolicy.org
- The Land Magazine and This Land is Ours (https://tlio.org.uk/ and https://www.thelandmagazine.org.uk/)
- Julian Hoffman: Irreplaceable: The Fight to Save Wild Places